

Meeting at the North Anna River

Ten days later, Grant left Spotsylvania and sent his advance units once more on the roads toward Richmond. The cat-and-mouse game began again, with Lee matching Grant's progress mile for mile, as rain lashed the slogging troops. Before darkness descended on May 22, Lee had concentrated his army behind the south bank of the North Anna River, 21 miles (34km) from the Confederate capital. Grant arrived on the opposite bank the next day. General Gouverneur K. Warren's Fifth Corps splashed across a shallow ford at Jericho Mill and was attacked that evening by a division from General A. P. Hill's corps. Warren drove Hill's troops off after a sharp and bloody fight.

4,500 The approximate number of Union and Confederate casualties at the North Anna River—where there was no major battle.



Pontoons on the North Anna River

On May 24, 1864, Union engineers constructed pontoon bridges across a fordable section in the North Anna River, where the banks were less steep, as depicted in this pencil drawing by Alfred Waud.

Union failure

The following morning, General Winfield S. Hancock's Second Corps crossed the North Anna 5 miles (8km) downstream, meeting little resistance. Hopeful rumors began to circulate that Lee had retreated again. In mid-afternoon, however, one Union division encountered Confederates near Hanover Junction, dug in behind entrenchments.